

A CLOSER
LOOK AT
OUR KEYS
TO SUCCESS

NOT JUST ANOTHER CAMP





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Launching a camp can be a daunting prospect. No matter the size of the camp, it is unquestionably a huge undertaking, carrying with it much responsibility. The effects, however, are immeasurable. Listening to the way the Rebbe spoke about camp throughout the years clearly indicates how much the Rebbe valued its significance and potential. Indeed, thousands of Jewish lives have been positively transformed by the Gan Yisroel experience. So, what is it that has made Gan Yisroel so successful all these years? And what is the key to success for Gan Yisroel camps today?



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"אמיתית השם 'מחנה' שייך רק כאשר מדובר אודות מקום שמתנהל ברוח התורה והיהדות — 'על פי ה' יחנו'. וענין זה מודגש באופן החינוך שמקבלים הילדים שנמצאים ב'מחנה גן ישראל', 'מחנה' שצריך להיות 'דוגמא חי' לכל שאר המחנות, שגם הם יתנהגו באופן המתאים, שאז יהיו הם ראויים לאמיתית השם 'מחנה'." (משיחת ש"פ עקב, כ"ף מנ"א, ה'תשמ"ג, תו"מ התוועדות תשמ"ג ח"ד ע' 1895)

"The true name 'מחנה' can only be used when talking about a place that is run in the spirit of Torah and Yiddishkeit, as the posuk says, 'על פי ה' יחנו', according to the instruction of Hashem they camped. "This is emphasized by the type of chinuch the children in Camp Gan Yisroel receive. It should set a positive example for all the other camps, so that they, too, behave appropriately and be worthy of the true name 'מחנה'." (Toras Menachem Hisvaaduyos 5743 v.4 p. 1895)

Though times may have changed since Camp Gan Yisroel's inaugural summer in Ellenville, New York in 5716, the goal and principles by which the Rebbe established it have not. Here is how camp directors throughout the years have worked to ensure that their camp indeed be worthy of carrying the Machane Gan Yisroel name.





BEING PROUD OF WHAT SETS US APART

“Though, over the years, the number of recreational summer options for children has multiplied, boruch Hashem, we are fortunate enough to have Yiddishkeit and Chassidus as our unique offering and we are maximizing it! It’s what makes us better and more attractive than any other camp.

—*Rabbi Boruch Shlomo Cunin,
Los Angeles, California*

“The Gan Yisroel brand as the Rebbe established it, was one of authentic Yiddishkeit given over in a fun and safe manner. We went to camp charged with fulfilling the Rebbe’s mission and were focused to give it all we had. Gan Yisroel’s claim to fame was always its highly dedicated, warm and energetic staff whose Chassidishe chayus and gefihl was contagious and infused every moment of each day. In fact, it was this unique chayus that was unanimously credited for quickly doubling and tripling attendance at camps across the globe.

—*Mrs. Simie Schtroks, Surrey, British Columbia*

“We retain the integrity of our standards throughout, just without an ‘in your face approach.’ For example, the camp is set up with separate divisions for girls and boys but they are each referred to with themed names instead of ‘Boys’ Division’ and ‘Girls’ Division.’ The highly anticipated ‘Special Activities Week’ is conveniently scheduled during the Nine Days, replacing the daily swim activities.

—*Rabbi Sender Engel, Long Beach, California*



Photo courtesy of Camp L'man Achai



למלא את הזמן בתוכן אמיתי

"אין להניח את הילד במצב של זמן ריק מכל תוכן, ואף אם הילד לא מרגיש זאת, הרי, האמת היא שאם אין בו תוכן, הרי זה זמן 'ריק' (כמודגש במקומות רבים בתורתנו הנקראת 'תורת חיים' — הוראה בחיים), אלא יש חובה למלא זמן זה בתוכן אמיתי.

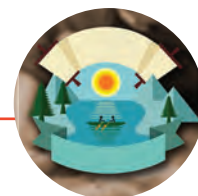
"אמנם, אין זה זמנה של שנת הלימודים, שבה ממלאים את הזמן ע"י הישיבה בבית הספר וע"י לימוד מתוך ספרי לימוד, אבל אעפ"כ, ישנה דרך נוספת, אשר, במובנים רבים, יכולה לפעול על הילד עוד יותר, כך שזמנו יהי ממלא בתוכן אמיתי, והיא: 'כאשר בחיצוניות נראה שמשפרים לו סיפור אבל תוכן הסיפור הוא עניני מוסר, ועוד יותר — תוכן חסידי. ועד"ז כשמראים לו שהמשחק שלו יכול להיות בצעצועים כאלו שמדגישים את חשיבות הצדקה, או העזרה לזולת, וכיו"ב. ולדוגמא — ע"י משחק בחיפוש 'אוצר', שבכך מודגש כיצד כל יהודי צריך לחפש את ה'אוצר' הטמון בעולם ובכל יהודי, כתורת הבעש"ט עה"פ 'כי תהיו אתם ארץ חפץ' — שהקב"ה אומר לכא"א מ ישראל, ולכל עם ישראל, שכל אחד מהם הוא עולם מלא, 'ארץ', שיש בה 'אבנים טובות ומרגליות' ברוחניות — הדבר היקר ביותר שיכול להיות, יוקר וחשיבות אמיתית, ברוחניות ובפשטות, ולכל יהודי ניתנה שליחות קדושה לגלות את ה'אוצר' בעצמו, ובכל היהודים שבסביבתו. (משיחת ט"ב סיון ה'תשמ"ו למסיימות ומדריכות, תנ"מ התועדויות ה'תשמ"ו ח"ג ע' 618)

"[In camp,] you shouldn't leave the child in a situation without any real value. Even if the child is being adequately entertained and doesn't recognize this lack, if there are no values being imparted, the time is really empty and wasted.

"True, [camp] is not the time of official classes, when the child learns from a sefer, but there are other ways to impart values to the child. When you tell a story, you can weave a valuable lesson, or even a Chassidic idea, within it. Similarly, you can use the games you play with the children as a way to teach about tzedakah or helping others, etc.

"For example, you can play 'hide and go seek' and, while playing, emphasize that this game teaches us that everything and every person in this world has a treasure that is hidden within him. The Baal Shem Tov explains the posuk יהי חפץ to mean that Hashem is telling every person, 'You are a complete world — ארץ — who is full of precious treasures — חפץ. And your mission on this earth is to reveal the treasure within yourself, as well as all the Yidden around you.'"

[Toras Menachem Hisvaaduyos 5746 v.3 p.618]



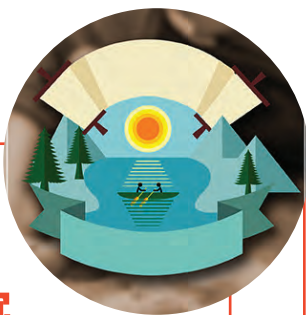
INFUSING EACH MOMENT WITH YIDDISHKEIT

"Whether it's a scavenger hunt, craft, or even clean-up, every part of every activity can and should be injected with kedusha. While playing ball, the ball and teams can each be assigned names that relate to the mitzva-theme being addressed that day or week. No matter the activity, nor the amount of time to be allotted to it, we must ask ourselves what messages the children will be taking home as a result, and ensure that we can answer satisfactorily."

—Rabbi Moishe Y. Engel, Long Beach, California

"The songs sung at lineup and while on the bus are a most powerful tool. They stay with a child forever and can pop up at the most unexpected of times. We have made it our business to pump up even the silliest cheer with a Jewish message and have seen the ripple effects on numerous occasions."

—Mrs. Simie Schtroks, Surrey, British Columbia



MAKING IT A FAMILY EXPERIENCE

“Though camp serves a purpose in and of itself, it should also be viewed as a window to so much more. The children who come have families and these families need to be touched, as well. When a father comes to collect his children, invite him inside and encourage him to lay tefilin. When the mother comes, speak to her about mikvah, about kashrus.”

—*Rabbi Boruch Shlomo Cunin, Los Angeles, California*

“At the end of the summer, we make a grand Shabbos party. All the parents, relatives and friends are invited to see the children perform and receive certificates and awards—it’s a mini graduation ceremony. This affords a superb opportunity to establish connections with many more people than we would otherwise have reached.”

—*Rabbi Nissan Dovid Dubov, Wimbledon, England*

“Our counselors visit the homes of each of their campers during camp. This allows their shlichus to impact the camper’s home and family as well as strengthen the keshar with the camper. Our community members really enjoy the opportunity to have a candid conversation with a Chassidishe girl and are often more open to discussions on Yiddishkeit with the counselors than with the rabbi or rebbetzin.

—*Rabbi Zalmy Kudan, S. Barbara, California*

REMEMBERING THAT IT IS THE REBBE’S CAMP

“Just as we must ensure that the Rebbe would be happy to enter our campsite at any given moment, we must also take care that the Rebbe would feel comfortable joining us on any of our trips off-site. Making a habit of consulting with a rov and mashpia, as well as asking ourselves how the Rebbe would feel if he were to walk in at any given moment are great ways to help us keep ourselves in check.”

—*Rabbi Berel Mockin, Montreal, Quebec*

“We are very particular about whom we choose to join our team of counselors. The girls who are successful here are those who come to be a part of our shlichus. Working for Camp Gan Yisroel is working for the Rebbe’s camp, and our counselors commit to that before they get on the plane. Using webinars, trainings, multiple references, and intentionally designed interview questions we are able to identify and train the counselors who are ready for shlichus as opposed to those looking for a summer job.”

—*Rabbi Zalmy Kudan, S. Barbara, California*



SERVING AS LIVING EXAMPLES

"Children see straight through us. As such, in order for our songs and activities to make an impact, we need to ensure that we and our staff are truly modeling Yiddishkeit and yiras Shomayim at their best. Ultimately, what the campers observe in our behavior makes a more powerful statement than our most eloquent of words. And indeed, the most teachable moments are usually those that go unplanned."

—Rabbi Moishe Y. Engel,
Long Beach, California



א לבעדיקן ביישפיל

בשעת מ'ויל עפעס פועל'ן ביים מודרך ומחונך - דארף מען' צום אלעם ערשטן באווייזן דעם מודרך א לעבעדיקן ביישפיל, און אויב ניט, קען מען ניט מצליח זיין אין דערויף - און ווי מ'זעט בפועל אז דער מודרך ומחונך פרעגט, אז וויבאלד דער מודרך איז א "נאה דורש", דארף ער זיכער זיין א "נאה מקיים". ביז וואנעט אז בשעת מ'ויל פועל'ן ביי אים א געוויסער ענין, דארף דער מחנך ומודרך באווייזן אז ער טוט דאס כמ"פ ככה, ווארום דער מחנך ומודרך מאכט ביי זיך דעם חשבון, אז וויבאלד דער מודרך העומד על גביו טוט אין אזא כמות ואיכות, וועט ער יוצא זיין אויך ווען ער וועט טאן האלב דערפון, דריי-פערטל דערפון, אדער עכ"פ עפעס ווייניקער דערפון - וואס דערפון איז פארשטאנדיק, אז וויפל ער מאנט ביים מחנך, דארף ער באווייזן א לעבעדיקן ביישפיל אז ער טוט כמ"פ ככה, כדי אז ער זאל זיין זיכער אז דבריו "ופעולותיו (וואס "אדם חס על מעשיו ידיו") זאלן זיין בהצלחה (משיחת ש"פ קרח ה'תשל"ח)

"When a person wishes to affect his student, he must first serve as a living example. Otherwise, he will not be successful. The student rightfully believes that his teacher or mentor must practice what he preaches. As such, when a teacher or mentor wishes to make a specific impact, he must demonstrate to his student that he does this very thing, but to a far greater extent. This is because the student will reckon that since his teacher or mentor performs this to such degree, he—the student—can get away with doing half as much, or three-quarters, or even less. By the teacher or mentor serving as a living example to a far greater degree than that which he wishes to impart, he will ensure that his words and actions will be successful."

(Shabbos Parshas Korach 5738)





How can we empower our staff to live up to the Machane Gan Yisroel name?



Photo courtesy of Camp L'man Achai

► **Work with the Schools:**

Teachers, principals, mashpiim and Bnos Chabad staff can help get students geared up toward working in the Rebbe's mosad. If you plan to be near a high school or yeshiva, let the schools know that you are available to present a workshop or farbreng about the zechus and achrayus of working in Camp Gan Yisroel. Students can be educated as to the huge difference they can make, not only to the campers, their families, and the non-frum staff, but to the shlichim's children. School staff can then be encouraged to build on this by inviting other shlichim to speak, or initiating a "hachona" campaign in this regard.

► **Set a Good Example:** When the directors and head counselors are focused on ensuring that every moment of every day be one that is befitting for Machane Gan Yisroel, their enthusiasm and sensitivity will be contagious and automatically rub off on the staff.

► **Establish Chavrusas with Baalei Batim:** Having your staff learn b'chavrusa once or twice a week with baalei batim in your community is a win-win situation. The staff take the learning seriously and the community gains immeasurably, as well.

► **Create Incentives for Learning, Bikur Bayis and More:**

Earning an all-expenses-paid trip for learning a certain amount of time per week is one way to motivate staff. You can also pay staff members up to 35% of their wages as a bonus for attending minyonim and shiurim, as well as visiting local families.

► **Hire a "Counselors' Counselor":** Entrust one older staff member with the responsibility of planning after-camp activities and trips for the staff, as well as overseeing their general wellbeing. Maintaining open lines of communication with this staff member and requesting schedules and itineraries in advance will help you ensure that all is in order. Of course, though you may have appointed one staff member to assist with these matters, it is important for all staff members to see and feel that you are directly involved in, and care equally as much about the after-camp hours as you do to the goings on during camp hours.

► **Arrange Farbrengens:**

Arrange staff farbrengens once a week with local shlichim, and, if feasible, occasionally with the staff from nearby shlichim's camps.

► **Schedule Frequent Staff Meetings and Shiurim:**

The time that the staff spend at meetings and shiurim is the time to really impart what shlichus is all about. It's here that we teach the Chassidic approach to challenges, halocha, camp activities, and other issues that come up. Spending time choosing an impactful topic for the staff shiur and preparing it well, with PowerPoint productions, handouts, etc., lets the counselors know that you value their limud haTorah and Chassidishe growth as much as their performance during camp hours.



The Rebbe's Garden



In 2011, the Foundation for Jewish Camp released a groundbreaking study that clearly demonstrated that childhood camp experience has a significant impact—in some respects a highly substantial impact—on adult Jewish practices and commitments. This report has prompted many Jewish foundations to pour millions of dollars into the expansion of Jewish camps domesti-

cally and abroad. In 2014, the JCCA partnered with the Grinspoon Foundation to help strengthen their day camp network of 135 camps.

More than fifty years prior, without any statistical analysis or empirical data, the Rebbe foresaw how a camp experience can transform an individual and moved to plant a garden. “A person is compared to a tree, a young child like a small sapling,” the Rebbe stated in 5717 during his second visit to Camp Gan Yisroel. “Every small change to the sapling will impact the eventual growth of the tree. We have the unique opportunity to ensure that the next generation of Yidden grow as strong and tall Jews, proud of their heritage and inspired to ensure its continuity.”

Indeed, the Rebbe tended to his precious garden firsthand, ensuring that every detail was attended to in total perfection. The Rebbe traveled upstate in 5716, 5717 and 5720 to visit the camp - the only deviation from his daily routine throughout 44 years of nesius and his only travels outside of the five boroughs. The Rebbe saw Gan Yisroel as a garden of boundless possibility and entrusted his shluchim with the task of sowing the seeds of a Jewish future within it. And from those small seeds grew something so dynamic that a half century later Camp Gan Yisroel leads the world as the largest overnight and day camp network for Jewish children with 400 camps worldwide, 10,000 staff members, and a remarkable 150,000 children participating each summer.

“השי”ת יצליח אתכם, שתלכו בדרכים האמורים לעיל, הלך וגדל בעילוי אחר עילוי, ועד שבקרוב ממש ילכו לצאת אתכם לקראת משיח ולומר ‘ראו גידולים שגדלתי’, אלו הם הילדים שחינכנו, והם ראויים להיות חייליו של משיח (משיח’ס סאלדערס), שיבוא בקרוב ממש, בימינו, ויוציא אותנו מהגלות, בגאולה האמיתית, אמנ”.

(משיחת ט”ו תמוז ה’תשי”ז בג”י)

“Hashem should grant you all success in the abovementioned manner. You should grow to be taller and stronger, until the arrival of Moshiach when we will greet him and say, “ראו גידולים שגדלתי,” these are the children whom we nurtured and they are worthy of being Moshiach’s soldiers. May he come imminently and take us out of this golus with the complete Geulah, Amen!”

(15 Tammuz, 5717 in Gan Yisroel, Ellenville, New York) 



ואסיים בנקודה שקרובה היא ללבי...”
והנני - פארקאכט - אין דעם, זה כמה שנים,
והוא ע”ד עריכת דעי קעמפ לימי החופש
מלימודי חול, שאז יכולים, בהכנה מתאימה,
לפטמם בלימודי קדש מבלי בלבולי לימודי
חול ובתי ספר העמים, ולמחנך ותיק בודאי
“האריכות בגודל הענין אך למותר
(אגרות קודש ח”ג ע’ רכט)

“I will conclude with a point that is close to my heart and in which I have been ‘farkocht’ for a number of years—that of arranging day camps for children [to attend] during their school vacation. With appropriate preparation it is then possible to infuse [the children] with limudei kodesh without interference from secular studies and the public school atmosphere. For an experienced mechanech like you, there is no need to elaborate.”

(Igros Kodesh v.13 p.229)



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